

When Ghibli fever gripped us all

Days, weeks and years down the line, as my smartphone's photos app reminds me of a sudden surge of Ghibli-inspired images in my gallery, I hope to look back and smile. In March 2025, OpenAI arguably had its most viral moment since it launched ChatGPT back in 2022. The reason was a routine update to ChatGPT that ended up being groundbreaking beyond measure. As OpenAI enabled image generation directly into the GPT-4o model, suddenly our beloved chatbot was no longer confined to text – it could now create images. And what did the digital world do? It erupted in an artistic explosion unlike anything we've seen. Out of nowhere, an unexpected and mesmerizing trend took over: Studio Ghibli-style AI art.

For those unacquainted, Studio Ghibli, co-founded by the legendary Hayao Miyazaki, is synonymous with enchanting storytelling, vibrant hand-drawn animation, and a soft-light pastel aesthetic that feels almost magical. Almost overnight, our X.com timelines became a surreal gallery of these dreamlike, AI-generated creations. Personal photos transformed into illustrations reminiscent of My Neighbour Totoro and Spirited Away spread like wildfire.

What makes these Ghibli-style images so special, you must be thinking? For me, it's very simple, as they bring a spark of genuine joy. Amid the ceaseless churn of data and the relentless march of algorithms, these images remind me – and evidently millions of others all over the world including here in India – of the beauty of nostalgia. They transport us back to the days when movies stirred deep emotions and art had the power to transport us to another world. It's that rare moment when technology, often criticized for desensitizing our lives, instead makes us feel something profound.

Therefore, the social media frenzy was something to behold. When you upload a simple selfie, the AI transforms it into an image that looks like it belongs in a Ghibli film – a world where everyday moments become extraordinary. Sam Altman himself joined in, sharing a Ghibli-style self-portrait. Even Elon Musk couldn't resist, transforming his image into a Rafiki-like figure from The Lion King, complete with his trademark irreverence. There's an undeniable



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allure to Studio Ghibli's art – its rich colors, intricate details, and whimsical charm evoke a sense of wonder that's hard to replicate. Everyone from Sachin Tendulkar to Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis, and everyone in between joined in on the action. Iconic movie moments, Olympic achievements, gags and memes all flowed with an unmissable Ghibli flavour, spurred by something greater than just social media FOMO.

In a world where our feeds are often cluttered with the mundane and the trivial, these Ghibli-inspired images remind us of what we're all capable of – creativity, innovation, and a spark of magic that technology, when harnessed well, can evoke. It's not just about reimagining photos, but about reawakening our sense of wonder. A sentiment that, frankly, has been in short supply lately.

Now, I know what some of you might be thinking, as you read this piece. Hayao Miyazaki, the man behind Ghibli, has been openly critical of AI-generated art. He's called it an “insult to life itself.” And, sure, his words carry weight. But here's the thing: while Miyazaki's stance is rooted in a deep respect for the artistic process, these Ghibli-style images aren't trying to replace the soulful craftsmanship of hand-drawn art. Instead, they serve as a joyful nod – a playful, perhaps even ironic, celebration of that very art.

When was the last time tech truly made you smile? When did you feel that raw, unbridled joy from a piece of innovation? If you can't answer that in under 30 seconds, it might be a sign that the relentless grind of our digital lives has dulled our senses. These images – each one a tiny burst of nostalgia and creativity – are a reminder that sometimes, technology can still surprise us. They cut through the desensitizing effects of endless notifications and algorithm-driven content, offering a moment of genuine delight.

Love it or hate it, Ghibli style AI-generated images are good for one simple reason – they make us feel alive. They remind us that behind every technological breakthrough lies the potential for pure, unfiltered joy. They are a testament to the fact that even as we dive deeper into the complexities of AI and digital innovation, there remains a space – a precious, fleeting space – for beauty, creativity, and connection. Even if it's just for a little while. **d**